

ECO403H1F
Topics in Development Economics and Policy

Department of Economics
University of Toronto

Fall 2026

Course description

This course will examine a variety of issues pertaining to economic development. Topics will include poverty and inequality, governance and institutions, human capital formation, and aid, trade, and migration.

The course will have a heavy emphasis on quantitative empirical methods. As a project-oriented capstone course, students will learn how to use economic tools and apply them to analyze questions in development economics.

Course information

Instructor: Eva Vivalt
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TA: Maryam Nainar
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Office hours: TBA

Organization: The course will use a flipped classroom: videos on the subject material to be covered in a lecture will be posted on Quercus for asynchronous viewing the week before a lecture, and we will discuss and answer questions during lecture.

Technical difficulties are not a valid excuse for failing to submit assessments on time, so please be careful (e.g., make back-ups).

Lectures and Tutorials

Tutorial: Monday 10 am-11 am
Lecture: Monday 11 am-1 pm

You are expected to have watched the lecture online before class. We will use the first hour of lecture each week (after the first week) to discuss questions relating to the video you watched. The second hour of lecture will be used largely for structured project support. Tutorial will include presentations on and discussions of papers on the reading list.

Pre-requisites

One of each of the following:

1. Microeconomics: ECO200Y1/ECO204Y1/ECO206Y1
2. Macroeconomics: ECO202Y1/ECO208Y1/ECO209Y1
3. Quantitative methods for economics or statistics: ECO220Y1/ECO227Y1/
(STA237H1, STA238H1)/(STA247H1, STA248H1)/(STA257H1, STA261H1)

At least one FCE in ECO at the 300+ level.

You must meet the prerequisites before taking this course. The Department of Economics will check them and strictly enforce them, removing students who do not meet all requirements. I cannot waive the pre-requisites.

I expect that you will be able to perform basic calculus (i.e., take simple partial derivatives) and have a basic understanding of regressions. Anyone without a basic knowledge of empirical methods will find the course challenging.

Requirements

The final grade for the course will be based on the following:

Percentage	Component	Due date(s)
10%	Participation	See notes
15%	Midterm exam	Monday, Oct. 5
10%	Critique of a paper	Monday, Sept. 21, Monday, Sept. 28, Monday, Oct. 19, Monday, Nov. 2, Monday, Nov. 9, Monday, Nov. 16, Monday, Nov. 23, Monday, Nov. 30, or Monday, Dec. 7 (see notes)
30%	Term paper, with the following breakdown: 5% Idea proposal (best of 2) 5% Project presentation 15% Term paper 5% In-class reflection	Monday, Sept. 21 and Monday, Sept. 28 for the proposal (see notes); Monday, Oct. 19, Monday, Nov. 2, or Monday, Nov. 9 for the presentation (see notes); Friday, Nov. 20 for the term paper;

		Monday, Nov. 23 for the in-class reflection.
35%	Final exam	TBD during final exam period

Participation: Given that this course leverages a flipped classroom, you will be expected to have watched a video in advance of each class (except the week of the midterm). In class, you will then be given activity sheets to do individually and in groups, building off the material you watched. You will be expected to write down your own answers to questions provided in class on paper, which you will hand in at the end of class. In order for this to go smoothly, and to avoid cheating, *you will generally **not be allowed to use your laptop, phone, or other devices in class*** until the second half of lecture (after those exercises are turned in). The videos will be posted alongside a pdf of the slides. You may bring printouts of the slides, if it helps you take notes or remember the material from the video better.

You will be graded out of 1 point for each activity sheet, and the best 8 sheets will count towards your participation grade. A legible, good-faith effort earns 1 point, even if there are some things wrong in your response. Getting a score of 1 on an activity sheet does **not** mean your answers were necessarily correct so do not rely on this grade as a signal of your understanding - it is a signal of your good-faith participation.

The remaining 2 points will be assigned for regularly participating in class discussion in lecture and tutorial, outside of the written exercises, as follows:

2 points: constructive questions/comments on multiple occasions, including at least one question or comment following a classmate's presentation in tutorial

1 point: occasional contributions but not regular participation

0 points: no contribution outside of other term work or exams

Midterm exam: More detail will be provided in class on the types of questions you can expect and how to prepare. The exam will be held Oct. 5 in class. The midterm will cover topics up to and including the week on "Issues in impact evaluation", including the "review" material on OLS and interpreting regression output. The pedagogical purpose behind having this material tested early is that we can get to a common understanding of methods, which will then be used through the rest of the course.

Critique of a paper: Each week (except the first week and the week of the midterm), students will present on one of the papers on the reading list, in groups of two (each group of two will present on a different paper, and the typical class will cover two papers). Plan these presentations to last 16 minutes. Following the presentation, the TA and other students may ask you questions for up to 9 minutes, and the TA may also use this time to make connections between the paper and other topics discussed in the course. In the presentations, you should describe the motivation of the paper you are critiquing;

what data and methods it used; and what results it found. You should also add your own original critiques of the paper. ***You are responsible for ensuring that every member of your group has a chance to critique the paper in some form.*** A sign-up sheet for these presentations will be posted on Quercus. You will be graded individually. It is great if your partner does great, but **how they do does not matter for your grade and you should not worry about it.**

Term paper: Students will complete the term paper individually. Each paper will be an extension of an existing journal article, e.g., a replication using updated data or new analyses. The journal article must make its code and data available. Students will identify their own project topics in development economics, subject to this limitation, and the topics must be approved. A list of journals will be provided for you to search for papers to replicate.

You will hand in a description of your idea for your paper on Sept. 21 and you will have another opportunity to hand in a revised paper idea on Sept. 28. The proposals should be 1 page long, maximum, and be submitted through Quercus. They must identify: 1) the name of the paper you are wanting to replicate and extend, and a link to the paper; 2) your research question and motivation: why someone should find your planned paper interesting; 3) a copied screenshot that proves that the data you will need for your analysis are available (include this image in the 1 page document). A template will be provided on Quercus. If your paper involves merging in external data, you need to show that both data sets exist and can be merged. Make sure to read about how the final paper will be graded before you pick a topic: if you do a basic analysis on a boring topic, you will not get a high mark even if you implement it technically correctly.

The final grade for the proposals will be given as a “best of 2”. For example, if your first idea receives 3/5 and your second receives 4.5/5, only the second will count towards your final grade. If you are happy with your grade after your first proposal, you do not need to submit a second one.

Students will also present on their in-progress papers after signing up for a timeslot. By the time of the presentation, you should have preliminary results and be able to interpret them. The presentations should each run for **strictly 4 minutes including questions**: 3 minutes of you presenting one result and 1 minute for questions. That is not much time! Stick to 2 slides, apart from the title slide: 1 slide on what you are doing and how, and 1 slide on results. The presentations will take place during lecture on Oct. 19, Nov. 2, and Nov. 9. To keep things moving quickly, your slides are due 2 days before your presentation, in a common format that will be posted on Quercus, so they can be strung together and be ready to go on the day and transitions between presentations are immediate.

The goal of these presentations is in part to help you prepare for your final paper. Therefore, plan accordingly. Try to create one key table/figure that you might want to include in your paper, so you can get early feedback and revise accordingly.

The paper is due on Friday, Nov. 20. You should structure your work on the paper so that you get the bulk of it done early.

The paper has a firm page limit of 7 pages, double-spaced. Each paper should include a maximum of 1 table and 1 figure (not included in the page limit) and a bibliography (also not included in the page limit). Students must also submit clean replication files with their project (i.e., both the data and the code used on those data, such that a third party could obtain the same results by running the code on the data).

On November 23, time will be set aside in the second half of lecture to do an in-class reflective exercise based on the paper, in which you will fully describe what you did in your paper and why, as well as challenges you encountered.

GenAI: AI can write a paper for you in no time, but it will likely not be a good paper. Since it is now trivial to write *a* paper, the bar is higher: in this class, we will aim to write *great* papers. I expect you to iterate on ideas and do more ambitious projects than you could have done before. It's an exciting time, so let's discover interesting and useful things.

Practically, my policy is: you can use AI, so long as you credit it. But, you need to understand your paper thoroughly, top to bottom, including why it's interesting, how you did it, what you found, and any limitations. I reserve the right to quiz you on your paper, more generally. And, if AI tells you garbage and you don't correct it, or if you don't notice it has led you down a poor path, that's on you.

Treat AI like a research assistant - but you still need to guide it appropriately. Use of AI also does not excuse plagiarism. You are fully responsible for what you turn in. You cannot use AI for the in-class exercise on Nov. 23 (or any other in-class exercise).

Final exam: This will be run by the university during the normal final assessment period (date TBD). You will get more guidance on the kinds of questions to expect and how to prepare in lecture, closer to the time.

Class Schedule

Week of	Topic	Second hour of lecture
Sept. 14	General introduction	Project launch: what makes for a good topic? OLS review + Stata in tutorial
Sept. 21	Impact evaluation	Proposal clinic: data and feasibility
Sept. 28	Issues in impact evaluation	Proposal revision: refine/switch
Oct. 5	Midterm (both parts of lecture; no tutorial)	
Oct. 12	<i>Thanksgiving – no class</i>	
Oct. 19	Poverty and inequality	Project presentations

-Reading week-

Nov. 2	Migration and trade	Project presentations
Nov. 9	Geography and institutions	Project presentations
Nov. 16	Aid	Paper workshop
Nov. 23	Health	Paper reflection
Nov. 30	Education	Development in the real world
Dec. 7	Cumulative science	Review

As the weekly lectures are largely based on journal articles, they will provide the background to understand the strengths and weaknesses of different empirical approaches and practice in critiquing academic papers (useful skills for your presentations and papers).

There is no required textbook. A reading list comprising academic journal articles will be posted in Quercus.

Flipped classroom

You are responsible for watching the video posted before each class. (The class that has the midterm in it will not have a video attached to it.)

Course videos and materials belong to your instructor, the University, and/or other sources depending on the specific facts of each situation and are protected by copyright. In this course, you are permitted to download session videos and materials for your own academic use, but you should not copy, share, or use them for any other purpose without the explicit permission of the instructor.

Software

The course involves empirical analysis, so some kind of programming language or statistical software must be used. This course will use Stata.

Stata is more accessible to the beginner, and many journal articles use Stata (this will be important when it comes time for the term paper, as your life will be a lot easier if you can start with the replication files from the original journal article).

You can access Stata at Robarts Library (the TA can provide details in week 1). A free six-month license to “Stata/BE” may also be available, which should be sufficient.

If you already know another programming language, like R or Python: Way to go! That’s awesome! But, unfortunately, anything other than Stata won’t be accepted. You would have a harder time finding a paper to replicate and it would be too hard on the TA to evaluate your work in R along with others’ work in Stata. That’s the bad news. The good news is that you should find Stata really easy.

If you are: a) exceptionally experienced at programming in R, b) able to find an interesting paper to replicate that uses R, c) willing to put in extra work to explain your code *extremely* thoroughly, come to my office hours to discuss using R for your term paper.

Course website and communications:

We will be using Quercus to manage class communications, so it is **essential** that you log on and provide an email address that you check regularly! Make sure you are receiving notifications!

Videos to watch before class and associated lecture slides will be posted on Quercus. Additional readings, class announcements, and information about assessments will also be managed through Quercus.

Course policies

Examinations:

Appeals policy:

If a student wishes to appeal their midterm or final grade, or their grade on any other term assignment, they must submit a written explanation as to why they think their grade is mistaken.

You have two weeks from when an assignment's results are released to appeal the assessment's grade. The first week is a one-week "cooling off" period during which no appeals will be considered; you must submit your written explanation in the second week.

Please note that apart from trivial appeals such as points being added incorrectly, the entire item will be re-graded, and the appealed grade can be lower or higher than the original grade.

Missed term work policy:

A grade of zero will be given to students who do not write the midterm test or miss another assessment, unless an appropriate and convincing note is received within one week of the missed test or assessment explaining why the test or assessment was missed.

If you have a genuine emergency, you should email the instructor and TA by the deadline and supply one of the four forms of documentation approved by A&S:

- Absence declaration via ACORN;
- UofT Verification of Illness or Injury (VOI) Form;
- College Registrar's letter; or

- Letter of Academic Accommodation from Accessibility Services.

It is an academic offense to feign illness to avoid a test or other assessment.

If a student has been excused from a midterm exam, they will be permitted to complete a “make-up” test on Oct. 9.

- Consistent with university policy, there is no “make-up test” for the make-up test. A grade of zero will be applied if a student fails to take the make-up test.

The final will be governed by the University’s rules for missing final exams.

Late assignments:

Idea proposals and the term paper are due at 11:59 pm Toronto time on the assigned dates.

Late submissions for the idea proposals will receive a grade of zero.

For the term paper, the late penalty is 10% per day, for a maximum penalty of 50%. A term paper submitted more than 5 days late will be assigned a grade of zero.

You must submit your replication code as part of your term paper, as will be discussed in class and in the rubric for the paper. Failure to turn in the code on schedule for any reason (including submitting it but the file being corrupted) will incur the same penalties for the percent of the term paper grade that the replication code is worth.

E-mail policy:

I will do my best to respond to e-mail within 48 hours, but:

- a) Please consult the syllabus and Quercus before emailing. Most of your answers will be found there;
- b) Questions requiring an extended discussion are best addressed during office hours. Please consider whether your question is posed in such a way that it can be answered succinctly in a sentence or two, and for all other questions, please see me in office hours;
- c) Please put “ECO403” in the subject line. Thanks!

If you have been waiting for a response, please double-check these items. Messages without ECO403 in the subject line might go to spam!

Laptop/phone/electronics policy:

To encourage participation and learning, **you will not be allowed to use any electronics** like a laptop, phone, or tablet during lecture except during the “project workshops” in the latter half of some of the lectures.

There are several reasons for this. First, you go to lecture to learn, and students typically learn better without having distractions. Second, as described in the section on assessments, in our flipped classroom approach you will be asked to write your responses to questions on paper and hand them in during class. If you are using a device, I don’t know that it is truly you who is answering.

You can use your devices during the part of lecture where we will do hands-on activities directly relating to the term paper. Not every lecture will include these activities. You can also use your devices during the break in the middle of lecture, or if I otherwise allow it for some special reason. But by default: no devices in lecture.

Academic misconduct:

All suspected cases of academic dishonesty will be investigated following procedures outlined in the Code of Behaviour on Academic Matters. If you have questions or concerns about what constitutes appropriate academic behaviour or appropriate research and citation methods, please reach out to me. Note that you are expected to seek out additional information on academic integrity from me or from other institutional resources (for example, the University of Toronto website on Academic Integrity).

Ignorance of the rules does not excuse cheating or plagiarism.

Plagiarism Detection:

Normally, students will be required to submit their course essays to the University’s plagiarism detection tool for a review of textual similarity and detection of possible plagiarism. In doing so, students will allow their essays to be included as source documents in the tool’s reference database, where they will be used solely for the purpose of detecting plagiarism. The terms that apply to the University’s use of this tool are described on the Centre for Teaching Support & Innovation web site (<https://uoft.me/pdt-faq>).

Crowdmark:

This course will use Crowdmark, a collaborative online grading tool for marking and providing feedback on graded term assessments. Crowdmark provides efficiencies with grading, data recording, returning term assessments and handling regrade requests. Copies of student work marked in Crowdmark, including grading and feedback, will be available online to students for at least one year. Digital (i.e., online) copies will serve as the authoritative record for course administrative purposes, and paper copies of assessments scanned and uploaded to Crowdmark will be destroyed after the term has ended and final grades are approved. If students have questions about how their information is stored on Crowdmark, please contact your course instructor.

Accessibility:

Students who require accommodation must register with Accessibility Services:

<https://studentlife.utoronto.ca/service/accessibility-services-registration-and-documentation-requirements/>.

More generally, you may find other resources at Accessibility Services here:

<https://studentlife.utoronto.ca/department/accessibility-services/>.

The Academic Success Centre can also help you with your learning goals:

<https://studentlife.utoronto.ca/department/academic-success/>.

If you have any issues that affect you more than 3-4 days, please contact your College Registrar immediately so they can help: <https://www.artsci.utoronto.ca/current/academic-advising-and-support/college-registrars-offices>.

For course-related issues, please stop by office hours.

Safety:

If you are Covid+ or feeling unwell, please stay home. Please look out for each other and be sensitive to others in your class who may either be more at risk themselves or living with people who are more at risk. You never know everyone else's situation.